government to relent after they had betrayed VOC, ease the coercive pressure and perhaps even support them. But such hopes, ever unrealistic, were belied. If anything, the government acted with a renewed vengeance. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, who had tried to ingratiate himself with the government, was deeply disappointed as the hoped-for tide of official disfavour not turning. The loss of VOC was a double blow—the company had not only lost its prime mover but also its bargaining chip.

Alarm bells rang among shareholders from across the presidency. Shareholders from Salem wired K.R. Guruswami Aiyar stating that they had taken shares worth Rs 1 lakh and were fearful of their investment given the hostility of the local administration.[37] A similar message came from directors and shareholders from nearby Erode as well: 'The Erode directors and shareholders of the Tuticorin Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company have taken shares [worth] about Rs 25,000. They deeply grieve at hearing the interference of officials with the Co's affairs and please entreat government on our behalf to have Co's trouble remedied.'[38]

In desperation, the loyalist directors first sought to plead with Collector Wynch. When he turned a cold shoulder to them, they sought an audience with the governor, Sir Arthur Lawley. Eventually, the deputation of bigwigs —three from Tirunelveli and two from Tuticorin—met the governor on 1 April. Led by K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, the deputation consisted of four other members: M.R. Ramakrishna Aiyar, S.S. Mohamed Abdul Kadar Marakayar, S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai, and N.A.V. Somasundaram Pillai. All members of the deputation (with the possible exception of S.S. Mohamed Abdul Kadar Marakayar) were intimately connected with SSNCo.

Guruswami Aiyar acted as the spokesperson of the deputation. Though the stated purpose was to petition against the quartering of a punitive police force in the towns of Tirunelveli and Tuticorin and the imposition of a punitive tax, the transcript of the interview—running into thirty-two closely printed foolscap pages, and an important source for the writing of this book —shows that the discussion revolved around SSNCo and VOC. The text is an exemplary discourse on the liberal assumptions of the loyalists and the hypocrisy of their British masters. Invoking the logic of liberalism,